



Johnny Woods 1 — Fundamental Rhythms

The Juke Joint Trail — Playing Along | G harp, 2nd position

Source: traditional patterns adapted from Johnny Woods, after George Mitchell field recordings

What you'll need

All the demonstration tracks for this lesson — the Foundation Rhythms, the Mixing exercises, the Descending Riffs and Long Haired Doney Rhythm 1 — are played on a **G harmonica in 2nd position**. The Long Haired Doney *backing loop* (Johnny Woods himself playing) is in a different key: Johnny is on a **C harp**, so jam over that loop with your **C harp in 2nd position**.

About this lesson

This is Lesson 1 of the Johnny Woods Delta Style Series. Long before any riffs or licks, Woods sat on a chuffing, vocal-driven rhythmic pocket — that's the foundation everything else hangs off. Get these foundation rhythms under your tongue and you can play along with a Mississippi Fred McDowell or R. L. Burnside track all night without ever needing a fancy lick.

Foundation Rhythm 1

-Eee-YAH +who -Eee-YAH +who -Eee-YAH +who -Eee-YAH +who

Foundation Rhythm 2

+who -ee -YAH +who / +who -ee -YAH +who /
+who -ee -YAH +who / +who -ee -YAH +who

Mixing 1 & 2

Ex.1 = 1 / 1 / 1 / 2

-Eee-YAH +who / -Eee-YAH +who / -Eee-YAH +who / +who -ee -YAH +who

Ex.2 = 1 / 2 / 1 / 2

Eee-YAH +who / +who -ee -YAH +who / Eee-YAH +who / +who -ee -YAH
+who

Guitar Riff Copy

Descending Riff 1

+6 -5 -4 +6... -5 -4 +6 ...-5 -4 +6.... -5 -4 → into rhythm 1

Descending Riff 2

+6 -5 -4 +6... -5 -4 +6 ...-5 -4 +6.... -5 -4 -'3..... → into rhythm 1

Long Haired Doney

Solo rhythm to *Long Haired Doney*.

Long Haired Doney — Rhythm 1

+3-Yah+ho -1 -Yah+ho +3 -Yah+ho -1 -34 -Yah+ho /

+3-Yah+ho -1 -Yah+ho +3 -Yah+ho -1 -34 -Yah+ho

Backing loop is Johnny Woods on a C harp — switch to your C harp in 2nd position to jam over it.



How to Practise This Lesson

The Juke Joint Trail — Playing Along

Start with each *practise speed* file until the rhythm feels easy in your jaw and tongue, not just in your hands. Once the practise-speed pocket is locked, switch to the *full speed* version and try to ride on top of it — the goal is to disappear into the groove rather than play over it.

When Foundation Rhythm 1 and 2 feel automatic, work the Mixing exercises so you can phrase rhythms together. Drop the descending riffs into Foundation Rhythm 1, and finally take the whole thing into Long Haired Doney. For the Johnny Woods backing loop, switch to your **C harp** and stay in 2nd position — the same rhythmic ideas all transfer.

About Johnny Woods

Johnny Woods (1 November 1917 – 1 February 1990) was a north Mississippi hill country harmonica player and singer. Self-taught, he built his vocabulary by adapting field hollers from working farmland near Looxahoma, Mississippi. His playing leans hard on rhythmic figures and vocalised attack rather than long melodic lines — closer to fife-and-drum than to Chicago blues.

He's best known for his duet work with Mississippi Fred McDowell (1960s onward) and his later partnership with R. L. Burnside on the Swingmaster LP *Going Down South*. The solo recording *Mississippi Harmonica* on Oblivion (1972) is the cleanest way to hear Woods stretched out on his own.